Hacktech 2026

April 24-26, 2026

Email: hacktech@caltech.edu
Website: hack.caltech.edu
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Discord: discord.gg/J9k65XQm3f

General Information

Check-in:

- **Check-in will be from 3:00 to 5:00 PM on Friday, 4/24**.
- Check in at the location here within this time period. Also see maps below
- **You must bring your ID to check in!**
- **As this is an MLH affiliated event, you MUST review the MLH code of conduct prior to check-in https://github.com/MLH/mlh-policies/blob/main/code-of-conduct.md**
- After completing check-in, you will be directed to either Avery Dining Hall, Chen Neuroscience, or Annenberg, where you will set up and settle in.

Food:

- Where: Avery Dining Hall
- **Menu**
  - Friday Dinner:
    - Chipotle Burritos
  - Saturday Breakfast:
    - Bagels, Muffins, and Danishes
  - Saturday Lunch:
    - Panda Express Buffet
  - Saturday Dinner:
    - Taco Truck & Aguas Frescas
  - Sunday Breakfast:
    - Breakfast Burritos
  - Sunday Lunch:
    - BBQ Banh Mi

Wifi:

- Follow the instructions here to obtain access to “Caltech Visitor”

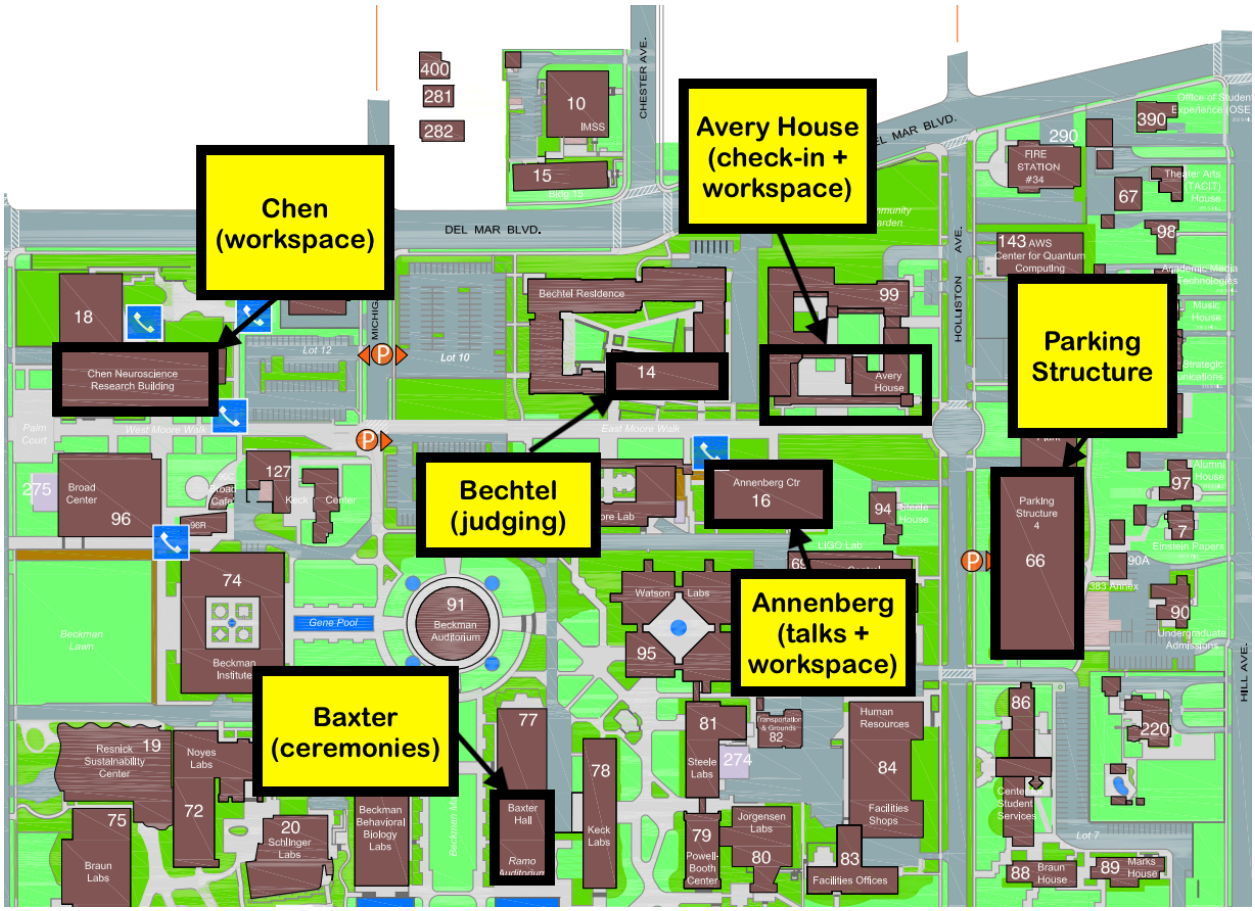
Competition/Event Rules

*****Note: all days/times given are in Pacific Daylight Time*****
Please note: Failure to adhere to rules may result in disqualification.

General Rules

- Teams must consist of 1 to 4 individuals.
- All team members must contribute to the group's project.
- Prizes cannot be negotiated.
- Teams may use libraries, frameworks, or open-source code as long as they credit or cite their sources.
- Teams are free to use AI tools to complete their projects.
- Adding new features to existing projects is allowed but must be clearly identified in the submission and presentation. **The use of an existing project will be taken into consideration during judging to ensure fairness**
- **Hacking must stop by 9:00 AM PDT on Sunday, 4/26/26.**
- **Projects must be submitted to Devpost by 9:00 AM PDT on Sunday, 4/26/26, without exception.**
- **Follow the submission guidelines as posted on the Hacktech Devpost**

Campus Map



Venue address (Avery House)

293 S Holliston Ave, Pasadena, CA 91106

Parking Structure address

370 S Holliston Ave, Pasadena, CA 91106

https://parking.caltech.edu/parking-info/visitor-parking

Main Tracks

TOTAL PRIZE POOL: $50,000+

Best Use of AI - Prize: Mac Mini m4 16 GB (provided by Extraordinary)

Cybersecurity/Safety - Prize: NuPhy Air 75 v3 Keyboard

AI Safety, traditional security, and more. As systems advance in capability and scale to unprecedented proportions, safety has become more important than ever. Develop algorithms, applications, and other software to secure cyberspace.

Creativity - Prize: MX MASTER 4 Mice

Tech is one of the most powerful canvases. What will you paint? This track is for projects that push the boundaries of generative art, interactive storytelling, novel user experiences, or tools that can empower the next generation of creatives.

"Not so sexy" - Prize: Whoop sports tracker / Watch

Skip the hype…let's talk about the stuff that might not be so flashy. This track is for hackers who find beauty in logistics, insurance technology, database migration, waste management, and other niches that the standard hacker may not think of. Bring us some solutions that solve trillion-dollar problems, but may not be so flashy on instagram. We need stuff that keeps the world running and can make a fortune while doing it.

Sponsored Challenges

YC x HackTech - Prize: YC Interview (1st), Partner Office Hours (2nd, 3rd)

Pick a YC company from before 2022 (i.e. from before ChatGPT came out), and build an AI-native MVP that reimagines or disrupts it for the world we live in now. This isn't about copying the original—this is about asking: "If that company were founded today, what would it look like with AI in the driver's seat?"
https://events.ycombinator.com/yc-hacktech-2026

Ironsite x HackTech - Prize: $10k (1st), $5k (2nd), $2.5k (3rd)

Pinpoint a key spatial task where current models fail. Create an innovative solution to solve the problem. Demo your technique. API Credits provided.
https://caltech.ironsite.ai/

IFM x Hacktech: Best Use of K2 Think V2 - Prize: reMarkable tablets

Build with one of the most capable open reasoning systems available. K2 Think V2 is a 70B-parameter model purpose-built for reasoning from the ground up — excelling at complex, multi-step problem solving across mathematics, science, coding, logic, and simulation. It features expanded context for sustained reasoning over large bodies of information, and is fully open end-to-end: pre-training data, post-training recipes, checkpoints, and evaluations are all publicly available and independently reproducible.

What we're looking for:

- Real, non-trivial use of advanced reasoning in real-world scenarios
- Creative applications beyond obvious LLM demos
- K2 Think V2 as a core part of your product, not a side API call

API Access: Join our WhatsApp group and share your team leader's email address to know more and receive your API key:
https://chat.whatsapp.com/KcLSzGS8M3kCXC6NM2bTT4?mode=gi_t

Sideshift x HackTech - Prize: $2k + work trial (1st), $1.25k + onsite (2nd), $750 + interview (3rd), interview (4th, 5th)

We're looking for the next billion-dollar consumer product. Web-based, iOS, any mix of design and backend works!

Palohouse x HackTech - Prize: 10-day stay @ Palo Alto Hackerhouse + $20k SAFE investment

We want to find the project/team that's closest to founding a company.

Listen Labs x HackTech: Simulate Humanity - Prize: $3k + interview (internship or full time)

Build a simulation of humans or societies. Model how people think, argue, change their minds, and influence each other. More information at hacktech.listenlabs.ai.

Judging

First Round (10:00 am - 12:00 pm) ~2hr

Science Fair Style

Each project is assigned a number, and each judge is assigned ~5-6 projects within a single track. Groups will present for ~5 minutes. Judges score projects using both the track-specific rubric and the AI rubric.

- Cybersecurity/Safety, Creativity, ”Not so Sexy”: The top 3 teams from each judging group, based on highest average scores, advance to the next round. Judges within each group may discuss results immediately after the round to resolve ties or advocate for standout projects.
- Best AI Implementation : The top 3 teams with the highest scores are selected as winners based on first-round evaluations. In case of ties or strong judge preferences, all judges may discuss and review video demos if needed.

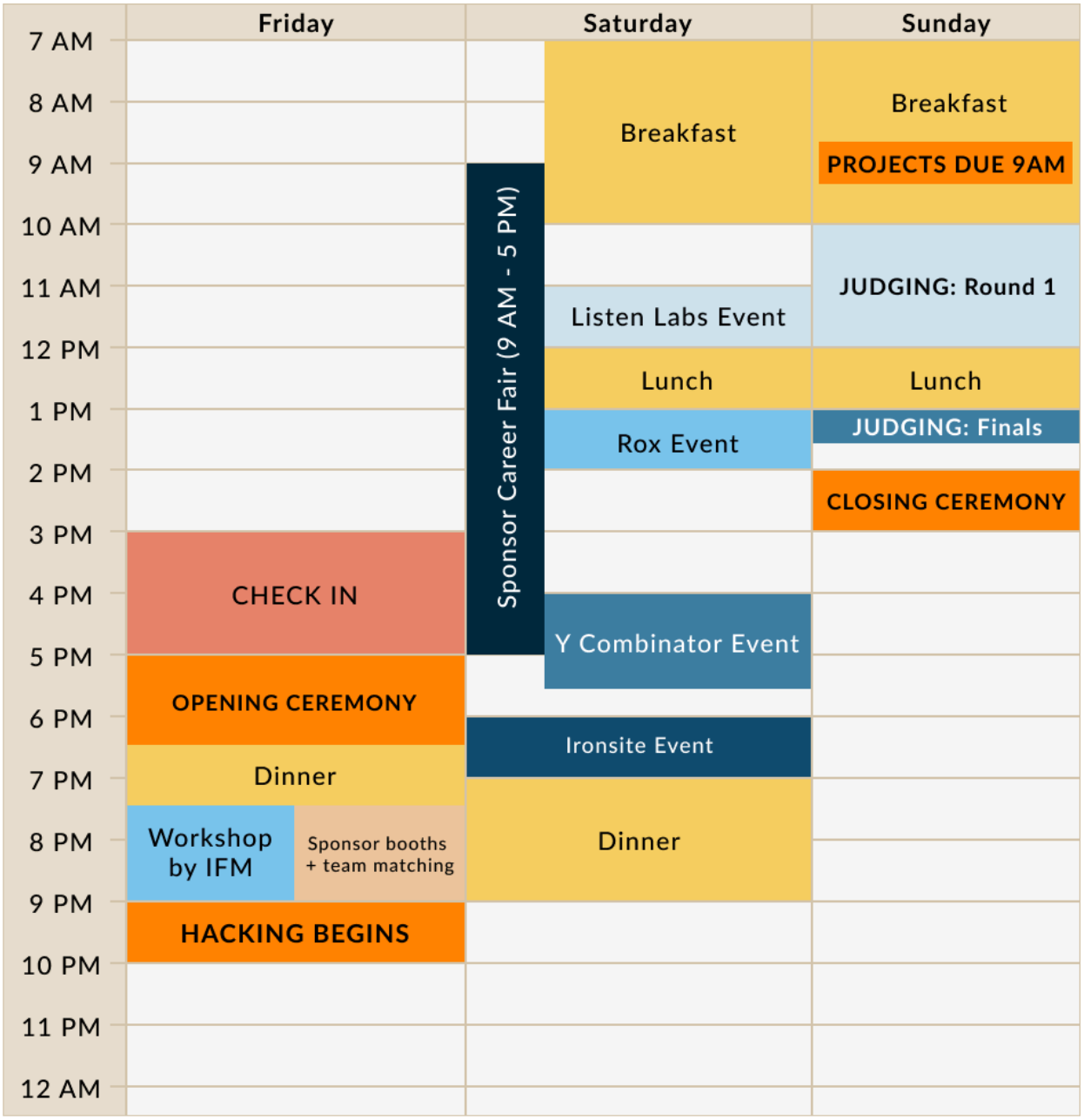
Second Round (1 pm - 1:30 pm) ~30 minutes

The top 3 projects per track (9 total) are selected based on first-round scores and judge deliberation. Each team presents for ~3 minutes in front of all judges and interested audience members (hackers are invited too!). Presentations occur consecutively.

- Cybersecurity/Safety, Creativity, ”Not so Sexy”: After all presentations, judges rank the top 3 projects in each track as 1st, 2nd, or 3rd. Rankings are averaged across all judges to determine the final winner. Additional discussion is allowed before finalizing decisions.
- Best AI Implementation: The top 3 teams for each award should have been already decided from the first round. If needed, judges may further deliberate or invite select teams to present before finalizing decisions.

Winners will be chosen after the second round. Results will be announced at the closing ceremony.

Schedule



*See detailed schedule below

Friday, 4/24

TIME	EVENT	LOCATION
3:00 - 5:00 PM (PDT)	Check-in **Please bring your ID!**	Moore Walk
5:00 - 6:30 PM (PDT)	**Opening Ceremony**	**Baxter Lecture Hall**
6:30 - 7:30 PM (PDT)	Dinner	Moore Walk
7:30 - 9:00 PM (PDT)	Team Matching	Avery Outer Courtyard
7:30 - 9:00 PM (PDT)	IFM Workshop + Talk	ANB 104
9:00 PM (PDT)	**HACKING BEGINS**	
9:00 PM - 10:00 PM (PDT)	MLH Workshops	ANB 104

Saturday, 4/25

TIME	EVENT	LOCATION
7:00 - 10:00 AM (PDT)	Breakfast	Avery Dining Hall
9:00 AM - 5:00 PM (PDT)	Company Career Fair	Moore Walk
11:00 AM - 12:00 PM (PDT)	Listen Labs Talk	ANB 104
12:00 - 1:00 PM (PDT)	Lunch	Avery Dining Hall
1:00 - 2:00 PM (PDT)	Rox Talk	ANB 104
4:00 - 5:30 PM (PDT)	Y Combinator Talk	ANB 104
6:00 - 7:00 PM (PDT)	Ironsite Fireside	ANB 104
7:00 - 9:00 PM (PDT)	Dinner	Avery Dining Hall

Sunday, 4/26

TIME	EVENT	LOCATION
9:00 AM (PDT)	**PROJECTS DUE**	
7:00 - 10:00 AM (PDT)	Breakfast	Avery Dining
10:00 AM - 12:00 PM (PDT)	Judging: Round 1	Bechtel Dining Hall
12:00 - 1:00 PM (PDT)	Lunch	Avery Dining
1:00 - 1:30 PM (PDT)	Judging: Round 2	Bechtel Dining Hall
2:00 - 3:00 PM (PDT)	**Closing Ceremony** **Winners Announced**	**Baxter Lecture Hall**